Spatial Instruction Following in World–Action Models

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Abstract: When a robot succeeds at *right of the bowl* but fails at *left of the bowl*, does it misunderstand the instruction, or is one placement harder in that scene? We study Cosmos 3 Nano and DreamZero-s2, a custom action-guidance configuration, in a simulated cube-placement task. For each model, 108 trials cross two commands with two object layouts while keeping the model, robot, cameras and controller fixed. Mirroring the objects changes DreamZero-s2 completion from 13/54 to 50/54. Most original-layout failures occur at pickup or transport. Nano remains highly successful, but which side it reaches farther reverses. At its goal-dependent endpoints, every matched pair has the requested LEFT/RIGHT ordering; a pretermination check preserves ordering but reduces separation. Thus scene layout can change task performance even when a model responds to the directional words.

Keywords: World–action models, spatial instructions, robot manipulation

1 Introduction

A robot asked to place a cube beside a bowl must recognize *left* and *right*, grasp, transport and release. The instruction can redirect motion correctly while placement still fails. Different LEFT/RIGHT success rates therefore do not show whether language failed to influence the policy or execution failed to complete the task.

This distinction matters for world–action models. DreamZero jointly models future video and actions, while Cosmos 3 supports world modeling and policy generation [1, 2]. Spatial following must still be established through robot behavior; world-model benchmarks likewise assess functional utility alongside visual quality [3].

We mirror movable-object positions while fixing the policy and commands. LEFT and RIGHT trials begin from the same state in each layout. We separately measure the final cube–bowl relation, requested-side depth and task success. DreamZero-s2 completion changes substantially with layout; Nano placement changes near a success ceiling. Task success and directional response can therefore support different conclusions.

2 Experimental Setup

Task and models. We evaluate Cosmos 3 Nano and DreamZero-s2 on a Rubik's-cube placement task in the DROID/RoboLab simulator. DreamZero-s2 is the DreamZero-DROID checkpoint with custom action-guidance scale 2; the baseline scale 1 is not used. The command is *Put the Rubik's cube to the [left/right] of the bowl*. It stays fixed for at most 450 actions, with no intermediate hints.

Scene intervention and repeated trials. The reflected layout mirrors the centers of all movable objects across the robot's forward midline. The robot, cameras, fixed scene geometry and controller remain unchanged. LEFT continues to mean the robot's left in both layouts (Figure 1).

Each model has 27 matched blocks. Each block runs both commands in the original and reflected layouts, giving 108 trials per model. Repeats within a layout share one starting physical state: these



Figure 1: **Change the layout, repeat the commands.** Both LEFT and RIGHT instructions are tested in each arrangement. Movable objects are reflected, while the robot and cameras remain fixed. The diagram is schematic; it does not show measured coordinates or a recorded trajectory.

are two layouts, not 27 scenes. Nano uses matched policy-sampling seeds. DreamZero-s2 fixes its noise seed, so repeats are not independent model-noise draws. We report models separately.

Measurements. Let $y_c(t)$ be the cube–bowl lateral offset for command c at recorded action t, positive to the robot's left. At a common action, the *instruction response* is

$$R(t) = y_{\mathrm{LEFT}}(t) - y_{\mathrm{RIGHT}}(t). \tag{1}$$

At separate terminal actions T_L, T_R, $R_{\mathrm{end}} = y_{\mathrm{LEFT}}(T_L) - y_{\mathrm{RIGHT}}(T_R)$. Positive response means LEFT places the cube farther left relative to the bowl than RIGHT. Because the bowl moves, this is a relational measure, not absolute cube-endpoint separation.

The *placement depth* is the final offset toward the requested side: y_{LEFT} for LEFT and $-y_{\mathrm{RIGHT}}$ for RIGHT. A larger positive depth means the cube finishes farther past the bowl on that side. We compare the two requests using

$$G = (-y_{\mathrm{RIGHT}}) - y_{\mathrm{LEFT}}. \tag{2}$$

Positive G favors rightward placement; negative G favors leftward placement. We measure its change between layouts within each trial block. Depth is a final position, not distance traveled from the start.

Task success requires release within 45 degrees of the requested direction from the bowl; lateral offset alone need not satisfy it. We use one rule in both layouts and measure all trials, including failures. These are executed simulator behaviors. Nano intervals use 20,000 bootstrap resamples of complete blocks; DreamZero-s2 is descriptive.

Both archived cohorts stop a success when the goal is first satisfied, while failures may reach the cap, so terminal positions are outcome-dependent. Only Nano retains stepwise positions. Its retrospective stopping check uses each pair's latest shared recorded action t_{pre} strictly before either trace terminates. This pair-specific action remains outcome-dependent, is not a common duration, and never carries a stopped trace forward. Action counts are simulator indices, not established physical time.

3 Results

Layout strongly changes DreamZero-s2 completion. DreamZero-s2 succeeds in 5/27 LEFT and 8/27 RIGHT trials originally, versus 25/27 each after reflection (Table 1). Completion rises from 13/54 to 50/54 with the same checkpoint, wording and controller. Original-scene failure is therefore insufficient evidence that direction words were ignored.

High success can hide changes in achieved placement. Nano completes 26/27 trials for each original-layout command, yet rightward depth exceeds leftward depth by 14.8 cm. After reflection,

Table 1: **Completion and instruction response differ.** Success counts have 27 trials each. R_{end} compares unequal goal-stopped endpoints; G is achieved placement-depth difference, positive toward RIGHT.

Model	Layout	LEFT success	RIGHT success	R_{end} (cm)	G (cm)
Nano	Original	26/27	26/27	44.8	$+14.8$
	Reflected	27/27	23/27	45.3	-10.0
DreamZero-s2	Original	5/27	8/27	12.2	$+2.3$
	Reflected	25/27	25/27	37.6	-11.8

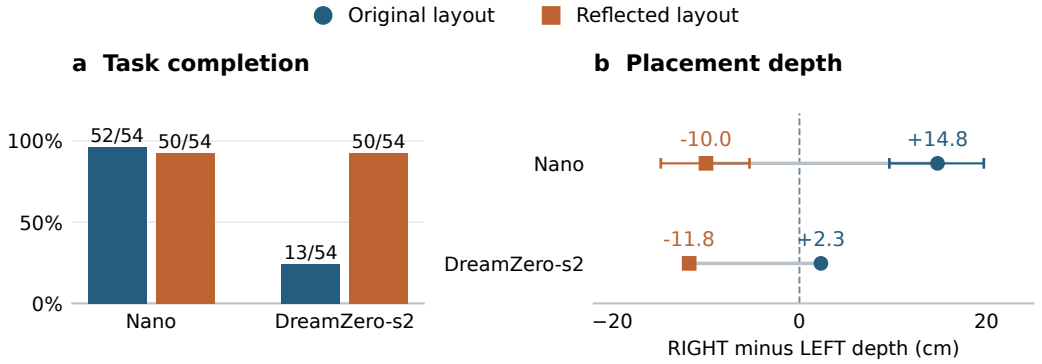


Figure 2: **The intervention affects models differently.** Left: successes out of 54. Right: mean depth gap G. Nano has 95% intervals over matched seed blocks; fixed-noise DreamZero-s2 is descriptive.

LEFT reaches 10.0 cm farther. The within-block change in G is -24.8 cm. DreamZero-s2 changes from $+2.3$ to -11.8 cm (-14.1 cm). Figure 2 contrasts these shifts with completion.

Most original-layout DreamZero-s2 failures precede placement. Of its 41 unsuccessful trials, the recorded checks classify 26 as pickup failures, 14 as transport failures and one as wrong-side placement. These categories describe execution stages, rather than what the model understood. They show why the overall failure count cannot be treated as a count of directional-language errors.

Instruction response and placement depth need not change together. At unequal goal-stopped endpoints, Nano has 27/27 ordered pairs in both layouts with mean R_{end} 44.8 and 45.3 cm; DreamZero-s2 has 26/27 and 27/27, with means 12.2 and 37.6 cm. Nano's latest shared strictly pretermination action retains 27/27 ordering, but mean $R(t_{\text{pre}})$ is 31.1 and 35.8 cm; pair actions span 89–290 (median 133) and 96–320 (median 149). At action 64 all pairs remain, but all four mean cube displacements are below 0.99 mm. At action 96, ordering is 20/26 (six reversed) and 25/27 (one reversed, one tie), with mean response 8.567 and 9.454 cm. At action 128 only 18/27 and 17/27 are observable; 17 and 16 are ordered, bounding full-cohort ordering at 17/27–26/27 and 16/27–26/27. At action 450 no matched pair remains. This retrospective stopping-sensitivity check is not A5 fixed-duration evidence or forecast accuracy.

Nano's mean change in G has a 95% interval of $[-32.4, -17.3]$ cm. This is variation across seed blocks in two layouts, not new-scene generalization. We make no independent model-noise inference for DreamZero-s2.

4 Discussion and Limitations

The results separate three questions: does language change the cube–bowl relation, how far does placement extend, and does manipulation succeed? Nano motivates continuous position near a ceiling; DreamZero-s2 shows layout-sensitive completion. The scene helps explain both scores.

World–action evaluation should repeat opposing commands from one state and under a controlled alternative layout, reporting object positions with completion. One arrangement can otherwise turn scene-specific difficulty into an apparent general spatial limitation.

The study covers two checkpoints, one simulated task and two fixed layouts. Reflection does not isolate reachability, visibility, grasp geometry or model components. The stopping check is retrospective Nano evidence from one base scene and its reflection, not 27 independent scenes, fixed-duration A5, or forecast accuracy. LEFT/RIGHT is not general language comprehension. Without policies lacking world modeling, we cannot identify its causal effect. Executed outcomes also do not establish generated-video accuracy; matching predicted and actual positions in physical time is a separate experiment.

5 Conclusion

Changing the object layout substantially changes spatial task performance without changing the evaluated models or their commands. Measuring instruction response, placement depth and completion separately shows what a success rate alone misses. This distinction is necessary when using manipulation benchmarks to assess spatial instruction following in world–action models.

References

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